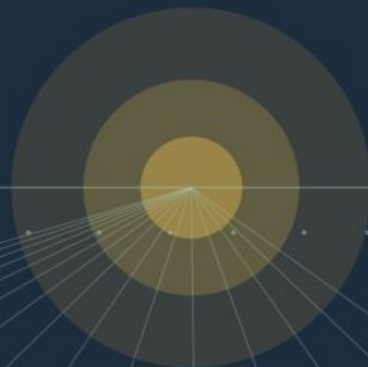


the good ship · a provocation

Responsible AI for organisations working in food systems

Responsible AI for organisations working in food systems ·
Food Ethics Council · developing in the open · 9 June 2026

Tom Watson · tomcw.xyz



who's talking

Tom Watson

I build tools and run programmes with organisations working for social purpose and I'm sceptical and hopeful about AI in roughly equal measure. Open-source and local-first by instinct. But mainly I like running and my garden.

The Good Ship · [TechFreedom](#) · [Bearing](#)

Work - <https://good-ship.co.uk/>

Writing - <https://tomcw.xyz/>

Socials - [Linkedin](#) & [Mastodon](#) & [Bluesky](#)



The Technological Richter Scale and AI Risk

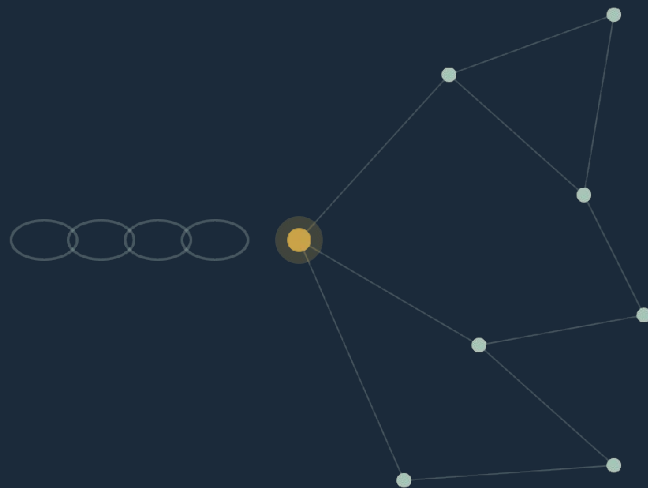
Net Impact of AI on Human Welfare According to Consensus Moral Framework

Technological Richter Scale	Historical Examples	Extraordinarily Positive	Substantially Good	Ambiguous	Substantially Bad	Catastrophic or Existential
	10 Epochal					
	9 Millenary					
	8 Centennial					
	7 Decennial					
	6 Annual	↑↑ AI has already passed this threshold ↑↑				

Not consumers at the end of the chain

Food citizenship says people are participants in the whole system, not just the last link.

Bring that same instinct to AI: don't receive it as a finished product, shape it, question it, help build it.



Give the hours back



The grant report, the meeting notes, the funder spreadsheet - the work that drains the people who joined to change the food system, not to feed a CRM.

Example · [Caddy](#), built by Citizens Advice, drafts the groundwork so advisers spend their time with people, not paperwork.

possibility · 02

See what was always hidden

Provenance, supply chains, who really benefits, patterns buried in data nobody had time to read. Surfacing them is an ethics tool, not just an efficiency one.

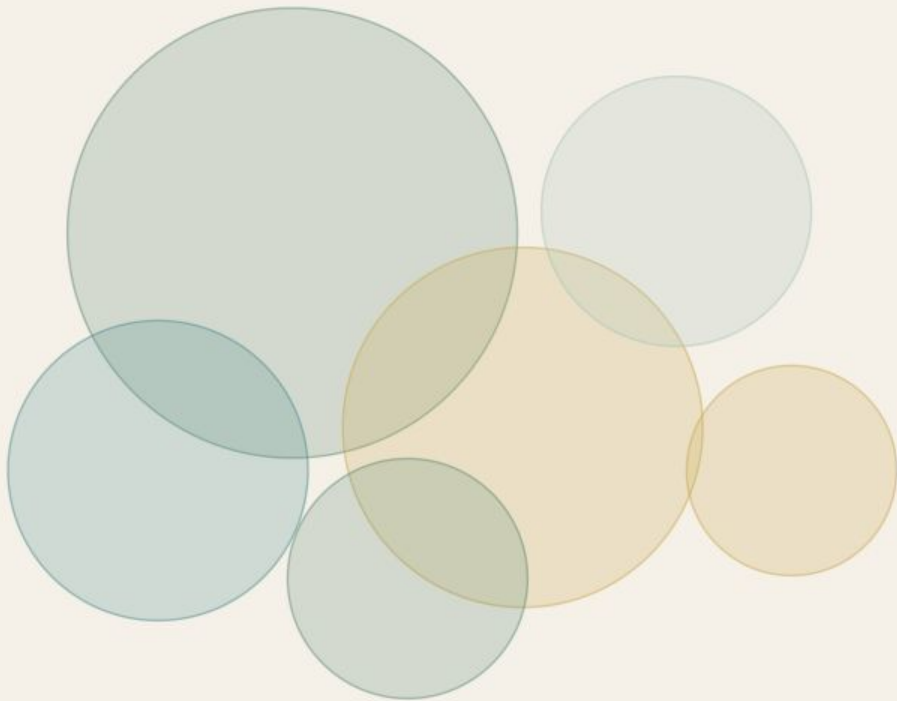
Example · [Open Recommendations](#)

More voices at the table

A right to food means living well, not just surviving.

The people a food system most affects are often the least resourced to engage with it.

Translation, plain-language, read-aloud all things perhaps AI can help with, if we point it there in the right way



the turn • moving at the speed of trust

Move fast and break things?

When we break things, it's trust and the communities most affected that break.

How fast, and who gets to set the pace?

FOMO is not a strategy

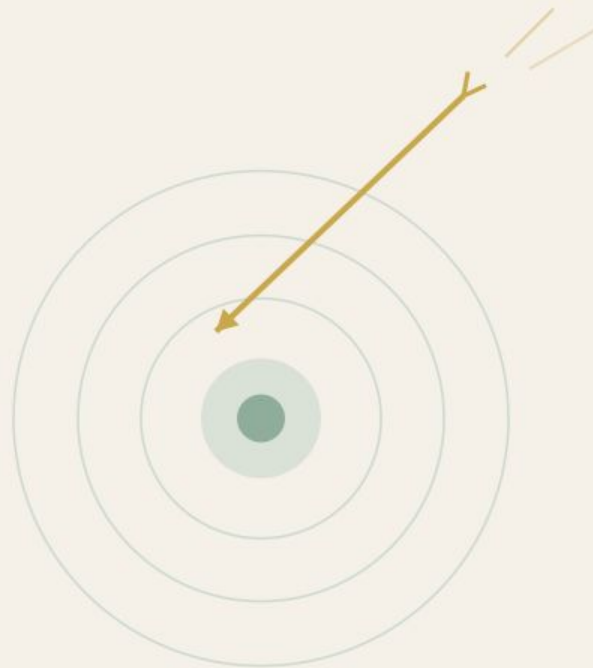
Adopt because it helps your mission, not because you're afraid of being left behind.

– *Rachel Coldicott*

“Efficiency is a trap”

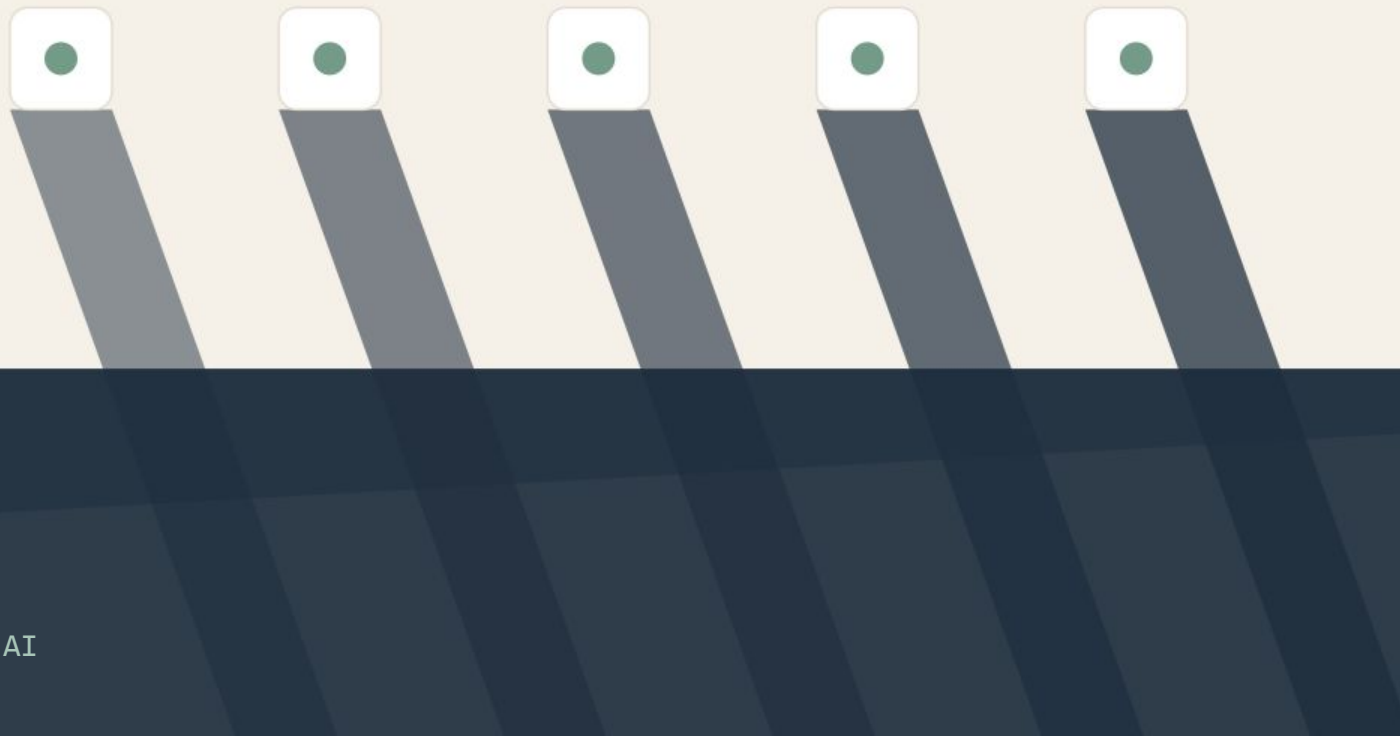
Doing the wrong thing faster is still the wrong thing. Chase effectiveness, the right outcome, not just speed.

- *Richard Pope*



a provocation

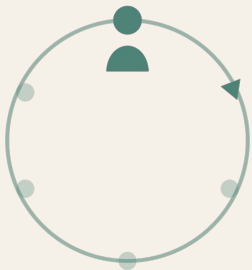
Beware the shadows



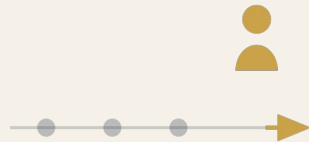
shadow IT → shadow AI

a provocation

Human in the loop — or human in the *lead*?



in the loop checking the
machine's work



in the lead setting
the direction

the thing that lasts

Principles outlive tools

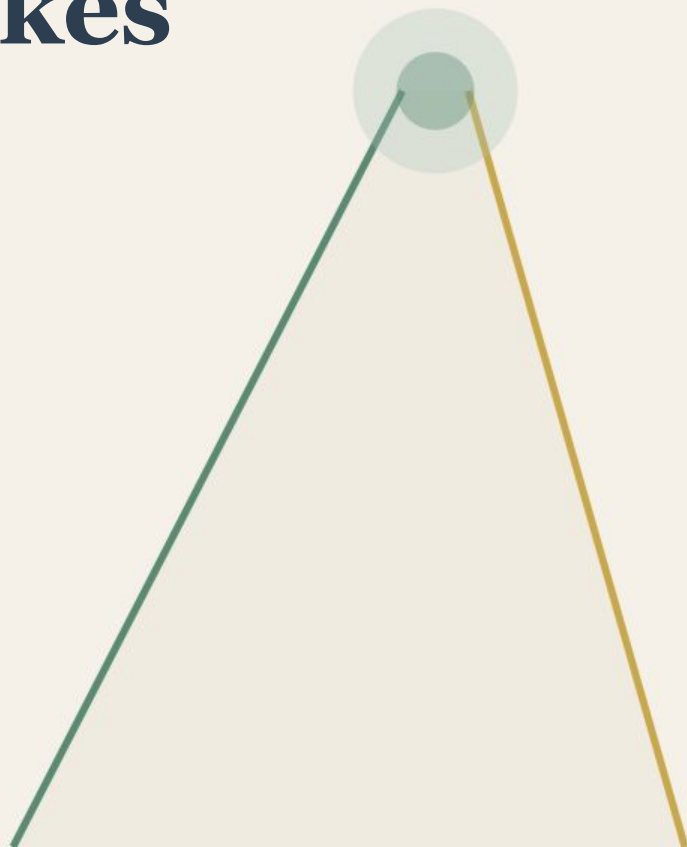
Tools will change - the ones you choose will look dated within a year.
Anchor the policy to principles that hold underneath, and don't write a policy for a single product.

the principles that hold

what holds the road

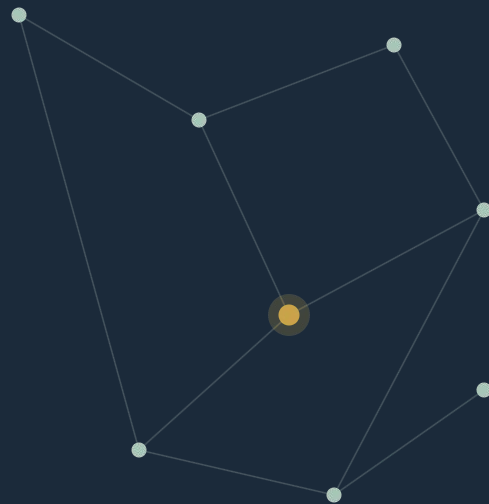
Guardrails, not brakes

- **Disclosure** say when AI shaped the work
- **Human review** a named person owns what you produce
- **Data boundaries** what do you put and it, where and how?
- **Pace of trust** adopt at the speed of the people affected



Others have already begun

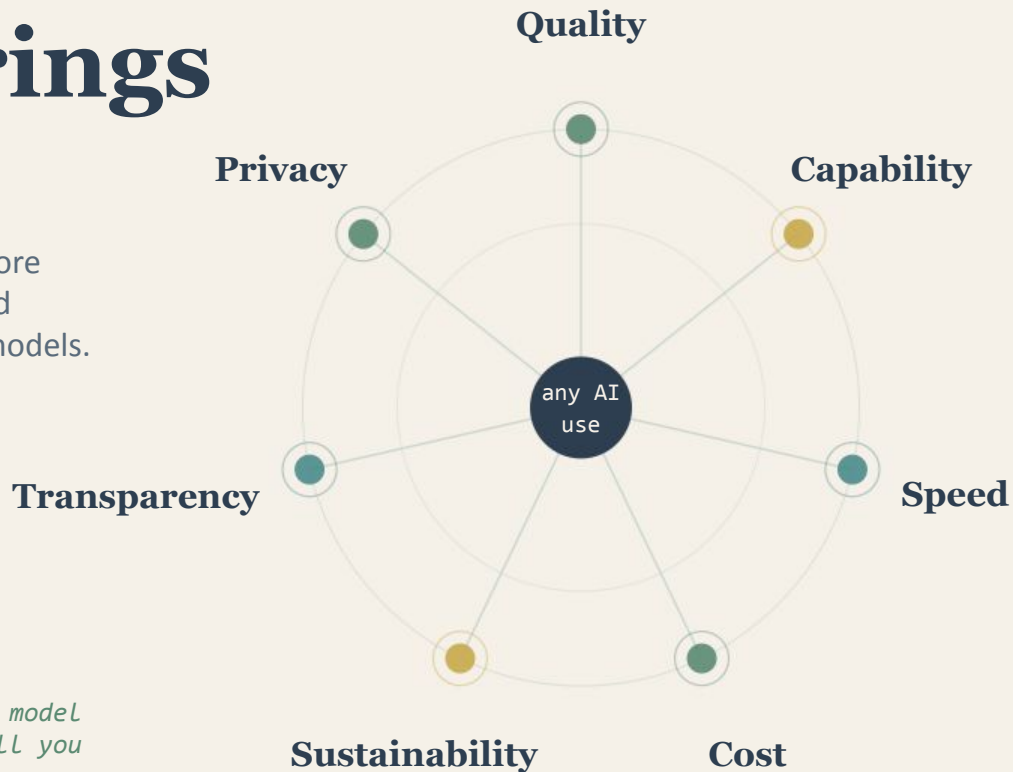
Learn from others. Keep discussing it.



a tool for discussion

Seven bearings

Hold any AI use up to these seven before you commit. They're the lenses behind Bearing, the tool I built for choosing models.



Note • open weights ≠ transparent. A model can be free to download and still tell you nothing about how it was built.

Or assess it as a dependency

Bearing asks whether a model is 'good'. TechFreedom asks what depending on it costs you. Five lenses for any tool AI included.

-  **Jurisdiction** Whose laws govern it, and where does your data actually live?
-  **Business continuity** If it changed or vanished overnight, what of yours breaks?
-  **Surveillance** What does it see, log, or learn about the people you serve?
-  **Lock-in** How hard would it be to leave and take your work with you?
-  **Cost exposure** Who sets the price, and can they raise it whenever they like?

one last provocation

If your policy were a
food label would you buy
it?

